

worst job I ever had was making bumpers for cars. I stood at a giant machine that ran 24/7. My job, hour after painful hour, was to take a strip of metal, place it on the line, pull my hands away, hit two red buttons simultaneously and—*boom*—the massive machine would clamp down on the metal, pressing it into a bumper in one swift stroke. I'd do this over and over and over again. Every bumper meant more money in the bank.

But then things started to get weird. I was terrified of having an accident. What if I didn't lift my hands in time? What if the safety tethers fastened to them didn't work? What if my hands got squashed into a bumper-shaped mash? What would become of me then? But when I raised my concerns with the foreman, he assured me that the machine would never clamp down without my hands being withdrawn through the safety tethers, and that the whole reason I had to hit two buttons simultaneously was to ensure that the machine would only work once my hands were safely away from the press.

I felt better after hearing that. Then, on my third day in the shop, I wasn't *anywhere near* the two buttons when the machine went *boom*. All by itself. I saw it with my own two eyes! I went to the foreman and told him what had happened.

"Nah, kid," he said. "You're just daydreaming. It's mind-numbing work. People hallucinate all the time," he told me. "The monotony is making you see things."

"Sir, I'm sorry to have to tell you this, but I am not seeing things. There's something wrong with that machine."

No matter what I said, he refused to believe me.

I saw the same thing happen three more times and complained at every instance, only to get the same shoulder-shrugging response. And that's when I had to take matters into my own hands—before I lost them. In my mind, I was thinking how much money my hands were worth to me, and no matter what dollar value I put on them, nothing was enough. That's when I decided, "Nope! Can't do this," and quit on the spot.

That was the worst job I ever had. I was lucky, for sure, that I never had a serious accident in any of these jobs, but apart from